



Preliminary investigation update

Rejected take-off and runway overrun, Tarlton Springs - Preliminary investigation update

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INVESTIGATION WORKFLOW SUITE

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Summary

On 18 June 2026, Saltbush Air SB512, a twin-turboprop registered VH-SBQ, rejected its take-off from runway 09 at Tarlton Springs Aerodrome after dark. The crew rejected at 118 kt, 6 kt above V1, when two kangaroos were seen on the runway. The aircraft struck the animals and came to rest 62 m into the 90 m runway end safety area. None of the 44 passengers, 2 flight crew or 1 cabin crew was seriously injured, although one cabin crew member reported bruising. The aircraft was substantially damaged, including the No. 2 propeller, the right main gear doors and the lower right fuselage, and the aerodrome was closed for 4 hours 20 minutes. The investigation is examining:

- how the animals reached the runway
- the wildlife management and runway inspection arrangements
- how the evening service was introduced
- the rejected take-off decision and stopping performance.

The operator suspended its evening Tarlton Springs service on 19 June 2026.

What we know

On 18 June 2026, Saltbush Air SB512, a 50-seat twin-turboprop registered VH-SBQ, was preparing to depart Tarlton Springs Aerodrome with 44 passengers, 2 flight crew and 1 cabin crew on board. It was the last scheduled sector of the day and the fifth sector of the crew's duty. The sector had been added that morning when the rostered crew reported unfit. The aerodrome was in darkness.

The aerodrome's only runway inspection that day was carried out at 21:35 UTC on 17 June, before the first scheduled arrival. It recorded the movement area as clear.

The doors closed at 07:16 UTC, 40 minutes behind schedule. At 07:29:10 the tower cleared the aircraft for take-off on runway 09, with the wind at 090 at 6 kt. The tower did not offer a runway inspection and the crew did not request one. The first officer was flying.

Take-off power was set at 07:30:02. The flight data shows both engines at matching torque, with no caution or warning, throughout the roll. The pilot in command called V1, calculated at 112 kt, at 07:30:29.

At 07:30:31 the first officer called two kangaroos on the runway. They were crossing from the northern side, at an estimated range of around 200 m. At 07:30:32 the pilot in command took control and rejected the take-off at 118 kt. This was 6 kt above V1, with 695 m of sealed runway remaining.

About one second later the aircraft struck the animals with the right main landing gear and the No. 2 propeller. The pilot in command's report describes striking at least one animal. Two carcasses were later recovered from the runway.

Maximum braking was established 2 seconds after the decision. Reverse was obtained on No. 1 only. The No. 2 reverse did not engage, and No. 2 propeller speed was recorded decaying from the moment of impact.

The aircraft left the end of runway 09 at approximately 21 kt at 07:30:51. It came to rest at 07:30:57, 62 m into the 90 m runway end safety area. It was upright, on the extended centreline, and 28 m short of the end of the prepared area. There was no fire.

The crew shut down both engines and did not order an evacuation. At the pilot in command's request, the tower activated the aerodrome emergency plan and a vehicle attended. Passengers left by the forward airstair. The operator's notification records the disembarkation as 4 minutes 8 seconds after the aircraft stopped.

The aircraft sustained the following damage:

- three No. 2 propeller blades damaged beyond limits
- right main gear doors distorted
- both right main tyres deflated through their fuse plugs
- two punctures in the lower right fuselage.

There were no serious injuries. One cabin crew member later reported bruising during the disembarkation. Two kangaroos were killed, and the aerodrome was closed for 4 hours 20 minutes.

What we are looking at

1. **How the animals reached the runway.** The investigation is examining the condition of the northern perimeter fence, the history of its repair on the aerodrome works register, and the aerodrome's wildlife sighting log. This is because both animals were recovered on the northern half of the runway, and an animal pad was found through the fence on that side.
2. **The framework for wildlife management at smaller aerodromes.** The investigation is examining how Aerodrome Standard AS-139 section 10.4 applies to an aerodrome of this size. Tarlton Springs falls below the thresholds that require a documented wildlife hazard management plan.
3. **Why no runway inspection was requested before departure.** The investigation is examining the operator's procedure at Operations Manual Part A 8.14. That procedure requires a runway inspection after last light only at aerodromes listed in Appendix 8A. The investigation is also examining how an aerodrome comes to be placed on that list.
4. **How the evening service was introduced.** The investigation is examining how change management record CMR-2025-118 assessed the new evening rotation. The route risk assessment for Tarlton Springs, RRA-041, carried a daylight-only restriction.
5. **The rejected take-off decision and stopping performance.** The investigation is examining:
 - the decision to reject above V1
 - the procedures and recurrent training that apply to that decision
 - how the strike and the loss of No. 2 reverse affected the aircraft's deceleration against the scheduled figures.
6. **Other matters.**
 - The investigation is examining the crew's duty day and the way the evening rotation is rostered.
 - It is also examining a fault found after the occurrence in the cabin floor proximity emergency lighting. The fleet-wide position on that fault is being established with engineering.
 - The investigation examined whether the intensity of the runway edge lighting affected the crew's ability to see the animals. Some of the lights measured above nominal intensity when checked seven days later. This question could not be resolved on the evidence available and remains open.

Containment and next steps

Interim action and containment

- **Evening Tarlton Springs service suspended.** On 19 June 2026 the operator's Head of Flying Operations suspended the evening Tarlton Springs service. It applies to the operator's scheduled evening rotation into the aerodrome. [NOT ESTABLISHED: whether the suspension remains in place, and any conditions for resuming the service]
- **Crew stood down.** Both crew members were stood down and tested after the occurrence. The results were negative.
- **Matters referred.** The investigation has raised with the operator's Safety Department how an aerodrome comes to be listed in Appendix 8A of Operations Manual Part A. It has also referred the fleet-wide position on the cabin floor proximity lighting ballast to engineering. No safety action has been recorded in response to either matter.

No other interim safety action or containment has been recorded.

Next steps

The investigation is:

- awaiting engineering's answer on whether the same ballast fault affects other aircraft of the type
- keeping open the question of whether runway edge lighting intensity affected the crew's ability to see the animals, which cannot be settled on the evidence now available
- completing its analysis of the matters set out above

The draft final report will be:

- reviewed by someone outside the investigation
- provided to the people and organisations it discusses so they can correct matters of fact

Any safety action that follows will be assigned an owner and a date.

The final report is expected [NOT ESTABLISHED: expected date of the final report].

Distribution

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